# Grammatical Features
# based largely on Goddard (2005) Chapter 4

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# Overview


1. Word order
2. Classifiers
3. Aspect
4. Serial Verbs
5. Subject and Topic
6. Sentence Final Particles (SFP)

# Outline

1 Word order

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# Two Word-Order Types in East Asia

| | Japanese, Korean | Mandarin | Thai, Malay, Viet. |
|---|---|---|---|
| verb, object | OV | VO | VO |
| adposition | postposition | preposition | preposition |
| relative clause | Rel N | Rel N | N Rel |
| possessor | Poss N | Poss N | N Poss |

- The features **line up**: OV languages put modifiers before the noun, VO languages after it
- Mandarin is the odd one out: VO, but relative clauses come first

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# Counting Needs a Classifier

| | | | order |
|---|---|---|---|
| Thai | *măa săam tua* | dog three CLF | N Num Clf |
| Malay | *tiga ekor anjing* | three CLF dog | Num Clf N |
| Vietnamese | *ba con chó* | three CLF dog | Num Clf N |
| Mandarin | *sān zhī gǒu* | three CLF dog | Num Clf N |
| Japanese | *san-biki no inu* | three-CLF of dog | Num Clf N |
| | *inu san-biki* | dog three-CLF | N Num Clf |

- Required with numerals and with vague quantifiers like *many*, *some*
- Number and classifier form a **phrase**, which can stand alone

# Why Have Classifiers?

- Nouns name **kinds**, like English *rice* or *water*: to count, you need a **unit**
- The classifier **individuates**: *three head of cattle*, *two sheets of paper*
- Classifier languages rarely have **obligatory plural** marking
- Inventories are shrinking: younger speakers lean on the general classifier (Mandarin *gè*, Japanese *-tsu*)

# Thai: The Classifier Phrase Stands Alone

(1) Mǎa kìi tua?
dog how.many CLF:animal
"How many dogs?" [tha]

(2) (Mǎa) sǎam tua.
(dog) three CLF:animal
"Three (dogs)." [tha]

# Malay: The Same, in a Different Order

(3) Berapa ekor anjing?
how.many CLF:animal dog
"How many dogs?" [zsm]

(4) Tiga ekor (anjing).
three CLF:animal (dog)
"Three (dogs)." [zsm]

# Four Kinds of Counting Word

| kind | counts | example |
|---|---|---|
| **sortal** | individuals | *san-satsu no hon* “three books” |
| **mensural** | amounts | *ni-hai no mizu* “two cups of water” |
| **group** | collections | *two pairs of shoes* |
| **repeater** | by the noun itself | Thai *taw* “vase” |

Sortal classifiers apply across the whole lexicon; the others are limited

# What Gets Classified?

| basis | example |
|---|---|
| **kind** | human, animal, tree |
| **function** | cutting, writing, eating and drinking |
| **shape** | long (1D), flat (2D), round (3D) |
| **consistency** | rigid, flexible |
| **size** | finger-sized, hand-sized, person-sized |
| **location** | towns, buildings |
| **arrangement** | row, coil, heap |
| **quanta** | head, pack, flock |

Shape and kind are the most common bases across languages (Allan, 1977)

# Japanese *-tsu*: The General Classifier

| used | example |
|---|---|
| for the residue | *yume-o hito-tsu mita*<br>"I had a dream" |
| as a default | *hon-o chōdo hito-tsu katta*<br>"I bought exactly one book" |
| when the thing is vague | *nantoka-ga hito-tsu hoshii*<br>"I want one thingamajig" |

Sortal classifiers pick out **kind** or **shape**; the general one is used when nothing is salient (Bond and Paik, 2011)

# Measure and Group Words

(5) 二 杯 の 水
ni hai no mizu
two CLF.cup of water
“two cups of water” [jpn]

*a flock of birds* *a herd of cows*
*a mob of protestors* *two bunches of bananas*

Group words are common in English and Thai, rarer in Japanese

# Repeaters: The Noun Is Its Own Classifier

(6) Mii taw dòòk-maj cak taw?
there.is vase flower how.many vase
"How many vases are there?" [tha]

Common in Thai and Lao, especially when no classifier exists for the noun

# Classifiers Can Show Respect

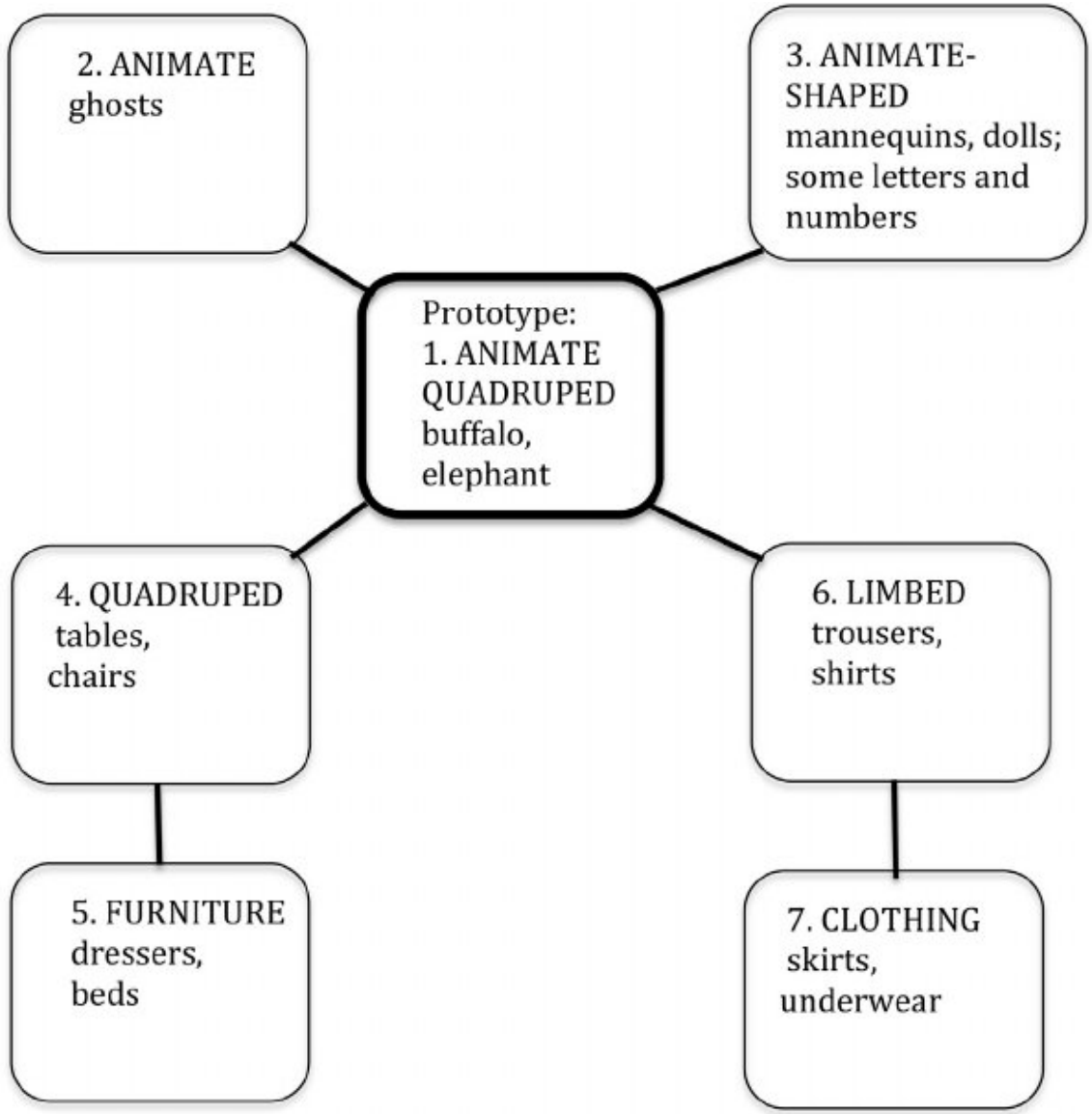
| "three people" | plain | honorific |
|---|---|---|
| Japanese | 三人 *san-nin* | 三名様 *san-mei-sama* |
| Korean | 세 명 *se myeong* | 세 분 *se bun* |

(7) 何　名　　様　　です か
nan　mei　　sama desu　ka
what CLF.person HON　is　Q
"How many in your party?" [jpn]

Khmer has special classifiers for royalty and monks

# A Classifier Is a Radial Category

Thai *tua*: animals at the centre, extended to furniture and clothing (things with legs or a body)



# Japanese and Chinese Sort Nouns Differently

| referents | Japanese | | | Mandarin | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| uncountable | — | | 29% | — | | 28% |
| events | 回 | *-kai* | 26% | 次 | *cì* | 26% |
| general | つ | *-tsu* | 21% | 个 | *gè* | 24% |
| people | 人 | *-nin* | 11% | 位 | *wèi* (HON) | 3% |
| concrete objects | 個 | *-ko* | 5% | 块 | *kuài* (lumps) | 2% |
| long thin | 本 | *-hon* | 2% | 条 | *tiáo* | 1% |
| flat | 枚 | *-mai* | 1% | 张 | *zhāng* | 1% |
| drops of liquid | 滴 | *-teki* | 1% | 滴 | *dī* | 1% |
| classifiers used | 47 | | | 81 | | |

- Default classifiers for 2,710 semantic classes in an ontology (Goi-Taikei), assigned by hand
- Mandarin has more, and more specific, classifiers; Japanese leans on *-tsu* and *-ko*
- 20% of classes take more than one: weapons are *-chō* (knives), *-hon* (long), *-furi* (swords), *-ki* (machines)

# Classifiers Can Count Indirectly

(8) 2-tsū-no denshimēru
2-tong-ui imeil
2-CLF.message-of email
"2 emails" [jpn, kor]

(9) 3-mai-no tegami
3-chang-ui pyeonji
3-CLF.flat-of letter
"a 3-page letter", not "3 letters" [jpn, kor]

(Bond and Paik, 1997)

# Noun Classes Are Not Classifiers

| | noun classes | numeral classifiers |
|---|---|---|
| number | 2–20, closed | 30–80 in use |
| realization | inflection | separate word |
| marked | on many words | in the noun phrase |
| examples | German, Bantu | Mandarin, Thai, Malay |

Gender is a noun class system: *der Hund* "the (M) dog", *das Mädchen* "the (N) girl" (Dixon, 1986)

# Swahili: Noun Class Agreement Everywhere

(10) Vi-su vi-dogo vi-wili hi-vi amba-vy-o ni-li-vi-nunua ni vi-kali.
8-knife 8-small 8-two this-8 which-8-REL 1SG-PST-8-buy be 8-sharp
"These two small knives which I bought are sharp." [swh]

Class 8 (plural objects) is marked on adjectives, numerals, demonstratives, relatives and the verb; a classifier appears only once, next to the number

Adapted from Saeed (2009, 181), citing Allan (2001, 310)

# Your Turn: How Would You Count These?

- Does a language you speak classify nouns? On what basis?
- Which classifier (or gender) would you use for:
  - a *watermelon*
  - a *grain* of rice
  - a *person*, a *teacher*, a *guest*
  - a *robot*

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New things get classified by **shape**, by **function**, or fall back to the **general** classifier

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# Aspect, Not Tense

**tense** *when* did it happen?
**aspect** *how* does it unfold?

- Many East and Southeast Asian languages have no tense
- They mark aspect instead: suffixes, auxiliaries, particles

# Kinds of Aspect

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **perfective** | the whole event | *She ran home* |
| **imperfective**: | the inside of the event | |
| progressive | ongoing | *She is running* |
| iterative | repeated | *The light is flashing* |
| durative | taking time | *He was sitting* |
| habitual | regular | *She runs every morning* |

# Aspect Markers in Mandarin and Cantonese

| | Mandarin | | Cantonese | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| perfective | V-*le* | 了 | V-*zo2* | 咗 |
| progressive | *zài*-V | 在 | V-*gan2* | 緊 |
| continuous | V-*zhe* | 着 | V-*zyu6* | 住 |
| experiential | V-*guo* | 过 | V-*gwo3* | 過 |
| delimitative | V-*yi*-V | 一 | V-*haa5* | 吓 |
| habitual | | | V-*hoi1* | 開 |

Aspect marking is independent of time reference

# Mandarin *-le*: Completion, Not Past

(11) Tā kāi-le mén, nǐ jiù jìn-qu.
3SG open-PFV door 2SG then enter-go
"(Once) she opens the door, you go in." [cmn]

(12) Nǐ gāo-le yìdiǎn.
2SG tall-PFV a.little
"You've got (a little) taller." [cmn]

*-le* works for future and conditional events, and with stative verbs

# Cantonese: Progressive and Experiential

(13) Wong4 siu2ze2 gong2-gan2 din6waa2.
Wong miss talk-PROG telephone
"Miss Wong is talking on the phone." [yue]

(14) Lei5 hai2 Hoeng1gong2 zyu6-gwo3 gei2noi6 aa3?
2SG in Hong.Kong live-EXP how.long SFP
"How long did you live in Hong Kong?" [yue]

# Cantonese: Habitual *-hoi1*

(15) Keoi5 zou6-hoi1 zung1dim2 ge3.
3SG work-HAB part.time SFP
"She normally works part-time." [yue]

(16) Keoi5 ji5cin4 zaa1-hoi1 Ben1si2 ge3.
3SG before drive-HAB Benz SFP
"She used to drive a Mercedes." [yue]

Regular or customary actions, present or past

# Cantonese: Delimitative *-haa5* "for a while"

(17) Tai2-haa5.
look-DEL
"Have a look." [yue]

(18) Jau1sik1-haa5.
rest-DEL
"Have a rest." [yue]

English uses *have a* V: *have a look*, *have a walk*

# Malay: Aspect Words Before the Verb

(19) Saya pun sudah beritahu juga semalam.
1SG FOC PFV tell also yesterday
"I already told (you) yesterday." [zsm]

(20) Bila saya masuk, dia sedang membaca.
when 1SG enter 3SG PROG read
"When I came in, they were reading." [zsm]

*sudah* marks completion, for past or future events; *sedang* marks ongoing action

# Singlish Carries the Pattern into English

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| perfect | *Eat already?* | "Have you eaten?" |
| experiential | *I eat durian before.* | "I've had durian before." |
| habitual | *He always late one.* | "He's always late." |
| continuative | *Your phone still spoil ah?* | "Still broken?" |

Singapore Colloquial English uses English words as aspect markers

# Summary: Aspect

- Aspect, not tense, is the core time category
- Marked by **suffixes** (Sinitic) or **words before the verb** (Malay)
- Perfective, progressive, experiential, habitual, delimitative

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# Serial Verbs: Several Verbs, One Clause

- Two or more verbs, **no conjunction**, one subject

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **loose** | a sequence of events | own arguments |
| **tight** | a single event | motion, posture |

# Loose Serialization: A Sequence of Events

(21) Dèèng paj³ talaat⁵ sùù⁴ khùang¹ maa² hùan² lèèw⁴.
Deng go market buy stuff come house PFV
"Deng went to the market, bought some stuff, (and) came home."
[lao]

One perfective marker covers the whole sequence

# Tight Serialization: One Event

(22) Dèk wîng pay síi khanŏm.
child run go buy candy
"The child ran (and) bought candy." [tha]

The verbs share their subject and describe a single event

# Pragmatics Decides What Counts as One Event

(23) nang¹ tii³ lanaat⁴.
sit beat lanaat
"Play the lanaat sitting." [lao]

(24) ? nòòn² tii³ lanaat⁴.
lie beat lanaat
"Play the lanaat lying down." [lao]

Nobody plays the lanaat lying down — unless the context makes it sensible

# Come and Go Give the Direction

(25) Khăw klàp maa lέεw.
3SG return come PFV
"She came back already." [tha]

(26) Khăw klàp pay lέεw.
3SG return go PFV
"She went back already." [tha]

Directional verbs work like adverbs: "hither", "away"

# Three Verbs: Manner, Path, Deixis

(27) Laaw² ñaang¹ khùn⁵ maa².
3SG walk go.up come
"She walked up here." [lao]

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| *ñaang¹* | walk | manner of motion |
| *khùn⁵* | go up | absolute direction |
| *maa²* | come | towards the speaker |

# Verbs That Work as Prepositions

(28) Laaw² nùng¹ khaw⁵ haj⁵ khòòj⁵.
3SG steam rice give(=for) 1SG
"He steamed some rice for me." [lao]

(29) Khan² haw² juu¹ nam² mèè¹-thaw⁵.
if 1PL live accompany(=with) mother-old
"If we live with your mother." [lao]

*haj⁵* "give" marks the beneficiary, *nam²* "accompany" the companion

# Vietnamese: “Arrive” Means “About”

(30) Chúng tôi nhắc đến anh luôn.
PL 1EXCL recall arrive(=about) brother often
“We often speak about you.” [vie]

Serial verbs can mark what is being talked about

# Japanese Compound Verbs Form a Cline

| | | literally | means |
|---|---|---|---|
| lexical | 取り締まる *tori-shimaru* | take-squeeze | manage |
| aspectual | 書き上げる *kaki-ageru* | write-raise | write up |
| | 歩き出す *aruki-dasu* | walk-out | start walking |
| syntactic | 食べ終わる *tabe-owaru* | eat-finish | finish eating |
| | 歩き始める *aruki-hajimeru* | walk-begin | start walking |

The aspectual ones are like English particle verbs (Hashimoto and Bond, 2005)

# Arguments Can Transfer

大阪を食べ歩く *Ōsaka-o tabe-aruku*

Osaka-ACC eat-walk

“stroll around Osaka eating”

寿司を食べ歩く *sushi-o tabe-aruku*

sushi-ACC eat-walk

“stroll around eating sushi”

The object can belong to either verb

# Summary: Serial Verbs

- Several verbs, one subject, no conjunction
- **Loose**: a sequence; **tight**: one event
- They do the work of English prepositions: direction, beneficiaries, companions

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# What Makes an English Subject?

| | |
|---|---|
| before the verb | *She seems happy.* |
| its own case | *I* vs *me*, *they* vs *them* |
| verb agreement | *he goes* |
| passive promotes | *Maxine was elected.* |
| any role | agent, patient, experiencer |

European languages add case and person-number agreement; the traditional view is that every language has subjects

# Topic: What the Sentence Is About

- In English, topic and subject usually coincide: *Cats eat mice.*
- In many Asian languages they **diverge**
- There, **topic** may matter more than subject

# Thai: Topic First

(31) Pàakphanang khâaw raw kin ngâay.
Pakphanang rice 1PL eat simple
"(In) Pakphanang, we ate simply." [tha]

- Typically SVO, but OSV and SOV are common in informal speech
- Subjects are often left out; order follows the discourse

# Mandarin: Topic First

(32) Zhāngsān wǒ yǐjīng jiàn-guo le.
Zhangsan 1SG already see-EXP CRS
"Zhangsan, I've already seen (him)." [cmn]

- Topics always come first; times and places are often topics: *In Taipei, one can eat well*
- Subjects are left out when context is clear

# Mandarin: Both Topic and Subject

(33) Xiàng bízi cháng.
elephant nose long
"Elephants, (their) noses are long." [cmn]

The topic sets the frame; the comment has its own subject (an ordinary, unmarked construction)

# Japanese: *wa* Marks Topic, *ga* Subject

(34) Hi wa nobor-u.
sun TOP rise-PRS
"The sun rises." (general) [jpn]

(35) Hi ga nobor-u.
sun NOM rise-PRS
"The sun is rising." (this one) [jpn]

*wa*: generic or contrastive, and for times and places; *ga*: the event as a whole

# Tagalog: The Verb Marks the Trigger's Role

(36) B<um>ili ang lalaki ng isda sa tindahan.
<AT>buy TRIG man GEN fish LOC store
"The man bought (some) fish at the store." [tgl]

(37) B<in>ili ng lalaki ang isda sa tindahan.
<PT>buy GEN man TRIG fish LOC store
"The man bought the fish at the store." [tgl]

Same event, same roles: the affix (*-um-* actor, *-in-* patient) says which role the **trigger** (*ang*) NP plays (Schachter, 1976)

# Tagalog: Any Role Can Be the Trigger

| trigger | sentence |
|---|---|
| actor | *Bumili ang lalaki ng isda sa tindahan.*<br>"The man bought fish at the store" |
| patient | *Binili ng lalaki ang isda sa tindahan.*<br>"The man bought the fish at the store" |
| location | *Binilhan ng lalaki ng isda ang tindahan.*<br>"The man bought fish at the store" |
| beneficiary | *Ibinili ng lalaki ng isda ang bata.*<br>"The man bought fish for the child" |

- The trigger is definite: *ng isda* "(some) fish" vs *ang isda* "the fish"
- Only the trigger can be relativized: *ang isda-ng binili ng lalaki* "the fish that the man bought"
- It acts like a subject, but any role can fill it: neither subject nor topic quite fits

# Acehnese: Actor and Undergoer

(38) Geu-jak.
3-go
"(S)he goes." [ace]

(39) Lôn rhët-lôn.
1SG fall-1SG
"I fall." [ace]

Prefixes mark **actors**, suffixes mark **undergoers** — not subject and object

# Summary: Subject and Topic

- European languages are **subject**-prominent; East Asian languages **topic**-prominent
- Topic and subject need not coincide
- Tagalog and Acehnese question whether subjects are universal

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# Particles Carry the Speaker's Attitude

- At the **end** of the sentence
- Speech acts: asking, requesting, persuading
- Feelings: surprise, doubt, hesitation
- Like English intonation, but explicit

| | one every | particles |
|---|---|---|
| Cantonese | 1.5 seconds | 30+, in 100+ combinations |
| Mandarin | 6 seconds | about 7 common ones |

Common in Thai, Lao and Vietnamese too; rarer in formal and written language

# Some Cantonese Particles

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 呀 | *aa1* | lively statement, question |
| 呀 | *aa2* | seeking confirmation |
| 噢 | *ak1* | abrupt disagreement |
| 啦 | *laa1* | requesting, seeking agreement |
| 囉 | *lo3* | emphasizing the current situation |
| 咩 | *me1* | surprise |
| 喎 | *wo3* | informative, noteworthy |
| 嘩 | *bo3* | exclamatory |
| 喇 | *laa3* | current relevance, advice |
| 咋 | *zaa3* | cheeky, intimate |

# Cantonese: Particles in Questions

(40) Lei5 gu2 gam3 jung4ji6 aa2?
2SG guess so easy SFP
"You think it's that easy, do you?" [yue]

| | |
|---|---|
| *aa2* | surprise or disapproval |
| *haa2* | presupposing agreement |
| *me1* | surprise, often rhetorical |

# Cantonese: Directive Particles

(41) Taai3 cou4 laa3, ngo5 fan3 m4 dou2.
too noisy SFP 1SG sleep not able
"It's too noisy, I can't sleep." [yue]

(42) Gam2 zau6 dak1 lo3.
so then okay SFP
"That'll be all right, won't it?" [yue]

*laa3*: current relevance; *lo3*: invites agreement

# Mandarin Particles

(43) Nǐ xǐhuan chī ma?
2SG like eat Q
"Do you like to eat (it)?" [cmn]

(44) Wǒmen qù ba.
1PL go SFP
"Let's go." [cmn]

(45) Tā ne?
3SG SFP
"What about him?" [cmn]

# Singlish Particles (1)

| | |
|---|---|
| *You must go lah.* | "You must go, okay?" |
| *I already said lor.* | "I already told you, see?" |
| *This one easy mah.* | "This one is easy, you know?" |
| *You sure can do it meh?* | "Are you really sure?" |

Chow et al. (2024)

# Singlish Particles (2)

| | |
|---|---|
| *Don't blame me what.* | "It's not my fault, you know?" |
| *She always like that one.* | "She's always like that, you know?" |
| *Your friend leh¹?* | "What about your friend?" (question) |
| *Eh, don't like that leh³.* | "Don't be like that." (persuasive) |

The tone of *leh* changes its meaning

# Conclusions

- **Classifiers** are needed to count, and sort nouns by kind, shape and status
- **Aspect**, not tense, organizes time
- **Serial verbs** do the work of prepositions and adverbs
- **Topic** can matter more than subject
- **Particles** carry the speaker's attitude

Southeast Asian languages (mainly East Asian) package meaning differently from European ones

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